

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Essay Simulation

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

SECTION A

1. India's energy transition is also a transition of jobs, regions and power.

Working thesis: Decarbonisation is usually discussed as technology substitution, yet coal sustains district economies, state revenues, railway finances and organised employment concentrated in a few eastern states. Replacing generating capacity therefore redistributes work, revenue and political influence. The proposition treats the transition as regional justice as much as engineering.

Structure: Establish the scale and geography of India's coal dependence. | Show renewables shifting activity towards different states and skill sets. | Analyse grid, storage and flexibility as physical constraints on ambition. | Introduce just-transition obligations to workers and mining districts. | Sequence coal decline against reliability and livelihood readiness.

Dimensions: Coal districts depend on wages, contracts, mineral revenues and freight earnings that renewable projects do not reproduce in the same places. | Renewable generation concentrates in high-irradiance and windy western states, shifting investment and employment across the federation. | Variable generation needs transmission, storage and flexible demand, so capacity added without evacuation strands both power and capital. | Just transition requires retraining, land repurposing and revenue substitution planned years before mines and plants actually close.

Examples: Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and Odisha depend heavily on coal royalties, mining employment and District Mineral Foundation funds. | Indian Railways has long cross-subsidised passenger fares from coal freight earnings, tying energy policy to transport finance. | Bhadla solar park in Rajasthan demonstrates enormous generation scale with comparatively limited long-term local employment. | The Ministry of Coal established a sustainable development cell in 2020 to address mine closure and environmental transition.

Counterview: Slowing the transition to protect coal regions creates its own victims. Air pollution, mining injury and climate damage fall on people who never received a coal wage, and delay raises long-run costs for every consumer. Justice for coal districts should be financed through transition planning, not purchased by postponing decarbonisation.

Conclusion: India can decarbonise while keeping the lights on, but not while ignoring the districts that powered the country. Transition funds, retraining and revenue substitution are the price of a politically durable energy shift.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

2. The credibility of welfare depends on the dignity of delivery.

Working thesis: A programme that reaches the intended household only after humiliation, repeated visits and dependence on intermediaries has already failed part of its purpose. Welfare is a statement about membership, telling a citizen whether the state regards her as a rights-holder or a supplicant. Delivery, not design, is therefore the decisive test.

Structure: Distinguish entitlement in statute from experience at the counter. | Describe the frontline state as the constitution citizens actually meet. | Assess technology as both dignity-enhancing and exclusion-creating. | Establish grievance redress as the completion of an entitlement. | Link dignity to take-up, trust and continued political support.

Dimensions: Legal entitlements shift the burden of failure onto the state, converting charity into a claim a citizen may actively enforce. | Frontline workers embody the state, so a teacher, nurse or ration dealer determines whether policy feels like a right or a favour. | Technology removes intermediaries and delay, yet authentication failure without fallback denies precisely the least documented claimants. | Grievance systems complete an entitlement through receipts, deadlines, appeals and published outcomes rather than informal intercession.

Examples: The National Food Security Act, 2013 provides a food security allowance when entitled grain is not supplied. | MGNREGA's dated receipts and wage-delay compensation make administrative failure a costed obligation rather than an excuse. | Kudumbashree organises women's collectives in Kerala that deliver services while members retain control over decisions. | Authentication failures at ration shops have denied entitled households food despite legally valid claims.

Counterview: Dignity is not free. Human-facing delivery is staff-intensive and discretion at the counter historically produced caste discrimination, bribery and political favouritism. Rules and biometric verification were adopted precisely because respect was granted selectively. The honest position requires enforceable rules together with adequately paid, supervised and respected frontline staff.

Conclusion: Welfare survives politically when taxpayers believe it works and claimants believe it respects them. Receipts, fallback options and answered complaints deliver both, at a cost far below the programmes they protect.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

3. Cultural diversity survives through living livelihoods, not museum admiration alone.

Working thesis: A craft or language persists when practising it remains a viable way to live. Admiration, documentation and display can preserve an artefact while the community that produced it quietly stops transmitting the skill. The proposition moves cultural policy from conservation of objects towards the economics of the people who sustain traditions.

Structure: Distinguish preservation of artefacts from continuity of practice. | Show transmission as an economic decision taken by the next generation. | Examine markets, credit and value capture for artisans. | Treat language use in schooling and administration as livelihood-linked. | Assess tourism and intellectual property as double-edged instruments.

Dimensions: Craft transmission depends on whether a young weaver can earn a decent living, since apprenticeship follows income rather than sentiment. | A language survives through daily use in schooling, work and administration, not through official listing alone. | Tourism can finance heritage while commodifying it, displacing residents or compressing a ritual into a shortened saleable spectacle. | Intellectual property tools secure value for producers only where the community, rather than an intermediary, controls certification and marketing.

Examples: Darjeeling tea became India's first registered geographical indication, tying reputation to a defined producing region. | Pochampally ikat and Channapatna toys carry geographical indication tags, though weaver and artisan incomes remain modest. | The Eighth Schedule lists twenty-two languages, while many smaller tongues lack school instruction and steadily lose speakers. | The National Education Policy of 2020 encourages mother-tongue instruction in early grades, supporting everyday language use.

Counterview: Markets can also destroy what they sustain. Commercial demand pushes artisans towards standardised tourist-friendly designs, and geographical indications have often enriched traders more than producers. Some traditions have no commercial future yet deserve public support, so documentation, subsidy and museum conservation remain necessary where livelihoods cannot be recreated.

Conclusion: Culture is inherited by young people who can afford to practise it. Fair prices, producer-controlled certification and living use in classrooms and workplaces protect diversity better than admiration from behind glass.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

4. Disaster risk is often development risk accumulated over time.

Working thesis: Hazards are natural; disasters are largely built. Construction over drainage channels, unregulated slope cutting, neglected maintenance and settlements crowded onto marginal land convert ordinary rainfall or tremor into catastrophe. The proposition reframes disaster management as an audit of past development decisions rather than an emergency-service problem.

Structure: Separate hazard, exposure and vulnerability as distinct components of risk. | Show land-use and construction decisions manufacturing exposure. | Show poverty and informality manufacturing vulnerability. | Analyse maintenance and redundancy as unglamorous risk reduction. | Position preparedness as the last line of defence, not the first.

Dimensions: Land-use decisions build exposure, because floodplains, wetlands and unstable slopes turn routine hazards into destructive events. | Infrastructure resilience depends on lifecycle maintenance and redundancy rather than on the completion of new assets alone. | Poverty converts a shock into a disaster, since insecure work, weak housing and absent savings block recovery afterwards. | Preparedness saves lives only when warning, evacuation, shelter and transport form an unbroken and regularly rehearsed chain.

Examples: Chennai's flooding in 2015 followed construction over the Pallikarai marsh and other natural water retention areas. | Kerala's floods of 2018 revived debate over the Gadgil and Kasturirangan recommendations on Western Ghats land use. | Joshimath's subsidence in 2023 highlighted construction and tunnelling pressure on fragile Himalayan slopes. | Odisha's shelter network and trained volunteers cut cyclone mortality dramatically after the 1999 super cyclone.

Counterview: Not every disaster is a development failure. Extreme events such as the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami or a great Himalayan earthquake would cause severe damage under any planning regime, and poorer societies face genuine trade-offs between immediate shelter needs and stringent standards. Risk can be reduced, but never planned away entirely.

Conclusion: The cheapest disaster policy is an enforced building code and an unbuilt floodplain. India's recurring losses are largely the delayed invoice for development choices made a decade earlier.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

SECTION B

5. Foreign policy begins at home but cannot end there.

Working thesis: External influence is financed domestically, by economic weight, technological capability, social cohesion and credible institutions. Yet the problems most affecting Indian citizens, including climate, pandemics, supply chains and maritime security, cannot be solved inside the border. The proposition binds domestic capability to unavoidable international engagement.

Structure: Show the domestic sources of external strength. | Demonstrate that key national problems are transboundary by nature. | Examine the diaspora as a two-way link carrying obligations. | Analyse coalition-building and reform of global institutions. | Balance autonomy against the real cost of cooperation.

Dimensions: Economic and technological capability set the ceiling on influence, since partners bargain over what a country can supply or withhold. | The diaspora carries remittances, skills and goodwill, while low-wage migrant workers abroad require consular protection and enforceable labour agreements. | Climate, oceans, cyberspace and pandemics are commons problems where purely national action cannot secure national outcomes. | Multilateral engagement lets India shape rules instead of inheriting them, which matters most for developing-country interests.

Examples: India is the world's largest recipient of remittances, tying household incomes at home to migration policy abroad. | Vaccine Maitri in 2021 converted domestic manufacturing capacity into diplomatic reach across developing countries. | The Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure, launched in 2019, exports Indian disaster experience into global rule-making. | Operation Ganga in 2022 evacuated Indian students from Ukraine, showing consular capacity as a foreign-policy obligation.

Counterinterview: Domestic capability does not translate automatically into influence. Wealthy states have repeatedly failed to convert resources into outcomes, while smaller countries punch above their weight through skilled diplomacy and agenda-setting. Conversely, commitments made ahead of domestic capacity can create obligations a country cannot honestly finance.

Conclusion: India's external ambition is credible only insofar as its economy, institutions and technological base sustain it, yet confining policy to the border would surrender rule-making on precisely the issues shaping Indian lives.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

6. Artificial intelligence will reflect the institutions that govern it.

Working thesis: Algorithms encode the data, purposes and permissions they are given. A society with weak data protection, opaque procurement and no remedy for wrongful automated decisions will build systems that entrench its existing failures at speed and scale. The proposition treats artificial intelligence as an institutional mirror rather than an autonomous force.

Structure: Reject technological determinism in favour of institutional shaping. | Show how training data reproduces historical patterns of exclusion. | Examine state use, procurement and the absence of appeal. | Assess labour effects as a distributional question. | Design regulation that permits innovation while assigning responsibility.

Dimensions: Training data encodes past decisions, so historical exclusion in lending, policing or hiring returns disguised as statistical objectivity. | Public procurement functions as regulation, because what the state buys sets the market standard for auditability and explanation. | Labour effects are distributional, since automation raises returns for some workers while devaluing routine cognitive tasks for others. | Accountability requires a named human decision-maker and an accessible remedy whenever an automated output harms an identifiable person.

Examples: The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 established India's statutory framework for processing personal data. | Puttaswamy (2017) supplies the proportionality standard against which intrusive automated state systems must be judged. | Police use of facial recognition in Indian cities has proceeded with limited public rules on accuracy and redress. | The IndiaAI Mission approved in 2024 funds compute, datasets and applications, shaping which uses become viable.

Counterinterview: Institutions also lag technology badly. Capability advances faster than any legislature can draft, leading models are developed outside national jurisdiction, and premature rules can freeze standards or entrench incumbents able to afford compliance. Governance must therefore rely on adaptive sandboxes, audits and liability rules instead of static prohibition.

Conclusion: India will get the artificial intelligence its procurement, privacy enforcement and grievance systems deserve. Building auditability and remedy now costs far less than reversing automated exclusion after it becomes administrative routine.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

7. Water disputes reveal the geography of politics and the politics of geography.

Working thesis: Rivers follow gradients while jurisdictions follow boundaries drawn for entirely different reasons. Conflict arises where an indivisible hydrological unit is governed by divisible political ones, each answerable only to its own electorate. The proposition captures a double causation: terrain shapes political conflict, and political conflict reshapes the use of terrain.

Structure: Set out the mismatch between river basins and state boundaries. | Explain how cropping and electricity policy convert shared water into rival claims. | Assess the tribunal mechanism and its chronic delays. | Add groundwater as the invisible dispute without any tribunal. | Suggest basin governance, transparent data and demand management.

Dimensions: Constitutional design places water largely with states while interstate rivers need Union adjudication, producing structurally contested authority. | Basin hydrology ignores boundaries, so upstream storage or diversion changes downstream livelihoods without any shared decision forum. | Cropping choices driven by procurement and free electricity convert agronomic decisions into interstate demands on limited flow. | Climate variability sharpens conflict by making flows less predictable exactly when allocation formulas assume stable long-run averages.

Examples: The Cauvery dispute ran from the 1990 tribunal to the 2018 Supreme Court award and the Cauvery Water Management Authority. | The Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal remains unbuilt decades after the Ravi-Beas allocation dispute between Punjab and Haryana. | The Interstate River Water Disputes Act, 1956 was amended in 2002 to impose time limits on tribunal awards. | Atal Bhujal Yojana, launched in 2019, addresses groundwater through community water budgeting in stressed blocks.

Counterview: Water conflict is not inevitable geography. Most Indian sharing arrangements function quietly, and disputes flare mainly when electoral competition rewards intransigence. Technical remedies also exist: better measurement, crop shifts, efficient irrigation and storage could ease scarcity enough that political geography would matter far less than it presently does.

Conclusion: Rivers cannot be redrawn, so institutions must be. Transparent flow data, basin authorities with real powers and demand-side reform in agriculture offer more than another decade of litigation over fixed shares.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

8. A constitutional democracy must protect both the mandate and the minority.

Working thesis: An election confers authority to govern, not permission to do anything. A constitution simultaneously honours the majority's right to decide and withdraws certain questions from its reach, so that today's losers remain citizens and may become tomorrow's winners. The proposition names the balance distinguishing constitutional democracy from simple majority rule.

Structure: Establish the democratic legitimacy of an electoral mandate. | Explain why entrenched rights are democratic rather than anti-democratic. | Examine judicial review and its own accountability problem. | Show deliberative institutions performing the everyday balancing. | Identify the failure modes at both extremes.

Dimensions: An electoral mandate authorises decisive government, and routinely blocking it converts constitutionalism into rule by unelected institutions. | Entrenched rights preserve the conditions of future majorities by protecting speech, association and equal citizenship from present power. | Judicial review polices constitutional boundaries but must justify itself through reasons, restraint and consistency rather than preference. | Deliberative institutions such as committees, consultation and a working opposition settle most conflicts long before they reach a court.

Examples: Kesavananda Bharati (1973) held that amendment cannot destroy the basic structure, limiting even a very large majority. | S. R. Bommai (1994) subjected the dismissal of state governments to judicial review and floor tests. | The Tenth Schedule, added in 1985, restrains defection while also constraining an individual legislator's dissent. | The general election of 1977 showed the electorate itself reversing the Emergency through the ballot.

Counterview: Balance can tip into paralysis or judicial supremacy. Courts staying legislation for years, or minority vetoes over ordinary economic policy, frustrate a government elected precisely to change course. Rights protection works best when narrow, principled and reasoned, so that constitutional limits never become an all-purpose objection to democratic choice.

Conclusion: Constitutional democracy is a settlement between winning and belonging. India sustains it when elections remain decisive, rights remain non-negotiable, and both sides accept that today's majority is a temporary trustee.

Model framework for practice; it is not an official or unique UPSC answer.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS